Golden Arrow

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/31095995.

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General Audiences

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Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

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F/F, F/M

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Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Spinnerella (She-Ra), Netossa (She-Ra), Double Trouble (She-Ra)

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by ChippedCat

Summary

Imagine the Etherians' surprise when their savior is the universe's first He-Ra

The Bow of Protection

Chapter Notes

> Countdown to Glimbow Week starts now! This is my fic for it, but since this first chapter has very little Glimbow in it, I figured I'd post it as a little teaser for you guys. I love this AU a lot and I'm excited to share it with the masses. This one segment turned into an absolute 3.5k monster, so it should satisfy you guys until later in the month.
> Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Glimmer wasn't happy when Bow got promoted. It got worse when he wanted to throw it all away and join the Rebellion.

"Tell me again what you saw." Glimmer rubbed the bridge of her nose with a sigh. Bow shifted in their shared bunk, although she had her own, and started over.

"I saw a sword,"

"Which, again, I didn't."

"And when I touched it,"

"That wasn't a smart move."

"It told me that I was the chosen one who had to balance the planet." Bow finished, despite Glimmer's helpful commentary.

"You realize how ridiculous this sounds, right?" Glimmer threw her hands in the air. "You're the chosen one? Sounds like Light Spinner really got into your head."

"Light Spinner doesn't have anything to do with this, Glimmer." Bow said firmly.

“I think you hit your head and had a hallucination where your brain just repeated what she’s always telling you. She never shuts up about how special you are.” Glimmer crossed her arms.

“It wasn’t a hallucination. I know what I saw.” He could still see it so clearly in his head like it was right in front of him. He could even hear those cryptic words ringing in his ears.

Balance the planet. What did that even mean? He was already doing that by working in the Horde. Soon, the whole world would be balanced under Hordak’s rule, and things would be better than ever before. What if that sword was a way to achieve that goal even faster?

“Even if you did see a sword, it’s gone now. The Woods are completely impenetrable.” Glimmer shrugged.

“We found it once.” Bow rebuked.

“And we won’t again, because it isn’t real!”

“But-”

“No buts. Bow, there’s no weird magical sword that only you can see. In the morning, I can take you down to the infirmary and they can get a look at your noggin. Until then, we should get to bed.”

“Please!” someone shouted from across the room.

“Shut up, Lonnie!” Glimmer yelled back.

“Right. Bed.” Bow nodded, still a little lost in thought. Glimmer laid down at the end of the bunk and nodded off quickly, but Bow couldn’t. His mind raced as he squeezed his eyes shut, willing himself to sleep like he had so many times after a long day of training.

He was a Force Captain now. He needed his rest.

Still, a small nagging voice reminded him, *You're a Force Captain now. You have access to skiffs*.

Eventually, Bow sat up with an internal sigh. The only way to put this behind him was to go to the Woods and see for himself that there was no sword waiting for him. Glimmer was right, of course, but he needed the assurance.

Quietly, Bow climbed out of bed and headed toward the skiff deck. This would be an easy mission, there and back before roll call. Glimmer didn't even have to know he was gone. It could be his little secret.

"There's something out here, Catra." Adora insisted, looking down at her pad. Catra glanced over her shoulder and cocked an eyebrow.

"I don't know how you understand that thing. It's just bright lights to me." Catra shrugged.

"Well actually, this trackerpad is made of assembled pixels, which together change colors to coordinate and form a picture, like the one you see here. So technically, it is just bright lights attached to a motherboard that tells which lights what image to produce." Adora explained.

"I can relate. I've got a motherboard of my own who's pretty bossy."

"C'yra's not that bossy, Catra."

"She's a queen. Bossy is her job, and she's great at it."

"She likes me."

"Everyone likes you, Adora."

"I can't help my natural charm." Adora said smugly. "I made you like me. I even convinced you to come all the way out to the

Woods with me. You hate the Woods."

"They smell, and this is *not* because I like you. I'm just sticking it to my mother by sneaking out after she grounded me." Catra defended.

"Sure."

"It's not!" Catra shoved Adora, and the two stumbled through a bush into a small clearing. There, the two girls stopped roughhousing. "What is that?" Catra asked with wide eyes. Before them, a massive sword was impaled in the ground, wrapped in vines.

"It looks like a sword."

"I knew *that*. But why is it here, of all places?" Catra reframed. "And why is it… glowing?"

"That must be what I'm tracking." Adora pointed at her pad and looked between it and the blade. "It's First One's tech!"

"Seriously?" Catra turned to Adora in disbelief.

"This is incredible! I assumed it was a massive cache with this kind of reading, but it's just one piece! This thing must be inordinately powerful." Adora said excitedly, facing her friend. "We have to get it back to Halfmoon."

"Is it even safe to touch? It's glowing an awful lot."

"We can throw a rock at it or something and see if it- Hey!" Adora cut off, turning to find a Horde soldier in the clearing with them, approaching the sword. "Horde soldier!" the soldier stopped and looked at them with panic in his eyes.

"He's going for the sword!" Catra growled. She yelled out and changed to her cat form, shredding her clothes. Adora pulled her staff out of her pocket and extended it to full-length.

"Wait-" he held up his hands, but Catra charged him with Adora close behind. Before they could reach him, the soldier pulled the sword from the ground and the whole clearing lit up.

Balance the world. Do not resist.

This power is not meant for you.

You must use it wisely.

You are not her!

Bow snapped awake with a start.

He expected to be bound; the Rebels were cruel like that. He didn't expect the massive cat-creature looming over him.

The creature, its face just above his, snarled as he opened his eyes. He was pinned to the ground, its paws over his limbs and open jaws heading towards his throat. "Catra, no!" a voice yelled. The creature paused, open jaw over his face as someone yelled at her. "No biting."

Bow risked moving his head slightly and saw a blonde girl off to the side, wildly gesturing at the giant cat. It was clearly the girl, the Rebel, he had noticed upon first seeing the sword, but now she seemed to be protecting him. Why?

"Catra, we've been over this." the girl said exasperatedly. She smacked her hand against her face and the cat, Catra, paused where she was. She didn't close her mouth, but her eyes went from Bow's throat to the girl and fixed on her with an annoyed glare. "We don't break people's necks before finding out their intentions." At least the creature seemed to be partially listening to the girl. Of course, the Rebels would employ giant beasts.

"Please tell your cat to get off me." Bow strained. Catra smacked the side of his head with one of her giant paws but closed her mouth and pulled her head up.

"She's not my cat." The girl corrected. "If anything, I'm her Sapien. She's the Princess of Halfmoon."

"A *Princess*?" Bow gulped. "Is that why she's trying to kill me?" were they both Princesses? That would be just his luck.

"She's not trying to kill you. *We* don't do that." The Rebel's eyes strayed to the Horde symbol emblazoned on his chest as she spoke. "Get off him. He probably has intel we can use." Catra snorted but jumped off him to return to the blonde.

"I wouldn't act so high and might." He reminded her, propping up on his elbows. "Princesses are killing this planet. Plus, your leader is a big furball." Catra narrowed her eyes, but the girl scratched at one of her ears with ease since it was the height of her chest, and she calmed slightly.

"That's it. Get up. We're taking you prisoner." she ordered. She pressed a button her staff and a handcuff attachment came out the end.

"I am not-"

"Yes, you are. Or maybe I can rescind the no-biting rule." She raised an eyebrow. Bow cut off, and his gaze drifted back to Catra. "She has the jaw strength to chomp right through a tree, you know." Catra grinned as best she could and Bow held out his wrists reluctantly.

"Glimmer will kill me if I let some massive cat eat me after I promised not to go into the Woods." He muttered under his breath as the blonde headed over to cuff him.

"I don't know who that is." She pulled him up with her staff and grabbed the sword off the ground where it lay a few feet away.

"Look, Rebel, I just came here for the sword. If you let me have it, I can be out of your hair in no time." Bow tried reasoning, though he knew it was no good. The Rebels were notoriously illogical.

"It's Adora, and I don't think so. I've been tracking this signal for a week, and I don't know what this does besides glow, but I know you can't have it. It would be way too dangerous in Horde hands. Plus, we were here first." She tucked the sword into her pack. "Catra, change back." She pulled out a set of clothes and placed them on Catra's back as she bounded up to them.

The cat took the clothes in her mouth and slunk off behind a tree.

"Did she rip off her clothes when she changed?" Bow asked quizzically. Adora blushed a little.

"She can't control her powers very well. Sometimes if she's just recharged, she can shift her clothes too, but that's a new ability for her."

"She has to charge her powers?" the Princesses might be less intimidating than he thought.

"Oh yeah. If she doesn't charge regularly, she can get stuck in beast-mode. It's kind of adorable but pretty dangerous since she could get stuck permanently if we aren't careful."

"Don't tell the Horde spy that!" Catra reappeared, adjusting the strange helmet on her head. Her appearance this time was only part cat, but Bow wondered why she didn't return to her full-Sapien state.

"Right." Adora winced.

"I have *excellent* control over my powers. I can change and shift back whenever I want with no consequences." Catra said confidently.

"I wouldn't go that far."

"Adora, don't mock me in front of the prisoner." Catra sighed.

"Wait, about that," Adora started casually, ignoring Bow. He huffed. The two were so busy pseudo-flirting that they forget he

was here. She tugged her staff and pulled him forward. “What are we going to do with him?”

“I’m right here.” Bow muttered.

“Let’s take him back home. That way, I can show my mom just how easy being part of the Rebellion is. She’ll have to be impressed and might even rethink her neutral status.” Catra put her hands on her hips.

“That’s optimistic. She’s been neutral for thirty years. I don’t think one caught soldier will change her mind.” Adora pointed out as the duo started walking. Bow was yanked along haphazardly, stumbling along whenever Adora pulled on her staff. “Besides, to do this, you will have to admit you went out while you were supposed to be grounded.”

“It’ll be worth it.” Catra decided after a minute of thinking. “Now, watch him. I’m going to scout the way a little to make sure he’s alone.” She jumped up onto a tree and scrambled up it effortlessly, disappearing into the leaves. Adora shook her head with a fond smile.

“You came alone, right? She’ll figure it out if you didn’t.” Adora turned to Bow. “Catra’s an excellent tracker.”

“I’m not telling my captors whether or not I have backup.” Bow said seriously.

“Whatever you prefer, Horde spy. You have the right to remain silent.” She shrugged, turning back to face the path.

They walked in silence for a little bit, the occasional rustling above their head the only reminder they weren’t alone. Yet, even with the audience, Bow’s questions welled up inside. He had never met a Rebel, let alone one as chatty as Adora seemed to be.

“You said she’s a Princess?” he asked after some time. Adora glanced behind her at Bow before slowing down a little to walk by his side. “The…. catgirl?”

“Yep. Catra’s the Princess of my home, so that kind of makes her my boss. It’s a little weird, but we’re friends, so that puts us on even ground most of the time.” She explained.

“And you’re not one?”

“No, I’m a commoner. Well, not a *common*er. I’m actually quite rare in our village. Not many Sapiens live in Halfmoon, let alone ones raised there.”

“Halfmoon…..” Bow racked his brain. “That’s the big territory in the Beast kingdom, right?”

“Beast?!” Adora frowned. “We don’t say that word, Horde spy. You’re lucky Catra’s not within earshot.”

“What, Beast? It’s what non-Sapiens are called.” Bow held up his hands, yanking Adora for once.

“Is that what they call Magicats in the Horde?” Adora softened her glare slightly. “Those monsters.”

“Hey, don’t talk about the Horde like that. You Rebels are the monsters. You took me hostage!” Bow shook his captive wrists.

“The Horde has done so much worse. That’s why you’re called the Evil Horde!”

“Who calls us that?”

“Everyone!”

“I can’t believe this. A *Rebel*, friends with a *Princess*, is telling me I’m on the wrong side. Who dumb do you think I am?” Bow laughed.

“I don’t know. I didn’t think anyone would be stupid enough to actually believe the Horde is the good guys, but here you are.” Adora rebuked.

“We are the good guys. You just can’t see it because your Princess friend has brainwashed you.”

“Oh yeah?” a voice in the trees called. Catra dropped in front of them, a surprisingly solemn expression on her face. “You want to see what the Horde really does?” she pushed aside a giant bush, and the trio came upon the ruins of a decimated town. Bow gasped.

“This…. this can’t have been us.” Even as he spoke, the red symbol of the Horde stuck out, burned into the side of a ruined home. This wasn’t right, but the evidence was too significant for his scientific mind to ignore.

“You see what they do to places they ‘liberate,’ what they want to do to all of Etheria.” Catra ran a hand over the Horde symbol, her face unreadable. “You see why we fight them.”

“I don’t know what to believe.” Bow admitted.

“Try believing your own eyes.” Catra growled, turning on him. “Look around you at the firestorm the Horde unleashed on this civilian town! If you can stand here and still say you’re fighting for the good guys, then you’re just as heartless as the soldiers who did this.”

“Catra, come on. He’s been indoctrinated.” Adora chastised. “You can’t expect him to just immediately turn around his entire world view.”

“No, she’s right.” Bow lowered his head.

“Or I guess you can.”

“This is the dark side of the Horde, the weeds that have to be cleared before new life can flourish. I’ve known that this kind of thing happens, but I never thought it was like this. I thought villages were dismantled and rebuilt so that the civilians could have better lives. I guess that was naïve of me.” This wasn’t the process Light Spinner had told him about it. It wasn’t the

deconstruction he had trained for. But then again, no one had taught him how to rebuild. Only to destroy.

Maybe he should have known this sooner. Maybe he always knew and pushed it down.

“I’m glad you learned your lesson, because when we get back home, you’re going in the dungeons, and you’re going to pay for your people’s crimes for the rest of your life.” Catra threatened.

“Now wait a minute! I don’t deserve that. I didn’t do anything.” Bow defended.

“I don’t care! You’re Horde, and the Horde is bad, so you must be bad.”

“That is terrible logic!”

“Catra-” Adora tried.

“I’m royalty. I don’t need logic.” Catra crossed her arms.

“Um, guys.” Adora got between them, but the bickering didn’t stop.

“If you want me to make up for my part in all this, have me help you fix it.” Bow argued.

“And you think I would trust *you* to fix things, just because you can light up when you hold up a Bow? You’re still the enemy, and nothing is going to change-”

A tree fell right next to the trio, nearly flattening Bow, and giant pincers emerged from the brush, an even bigger bug behind them.

“I was trying to warn you about the monster!” Adora yelled.

“It’s just a bug. We can take it.” Catra waved her hand dismissively as the creature screeched.

“My staff is attached to him, you really shouldn’t transform twice so close together, and that is much bigger than we’re used to. I say we run.” Adora said. The bug continued to regard them, looking at Bow with huge pupilless eyes. What was it waiting for?

“I can morph and take it myself then.” Catra shrugged.

“What did I just say?”

“It’s fine, I’ll just recharge when we get back.” Apparently, the bug didn’t like that idea since it chose the moment to attack, both pincers going for Bow. Adora released his handcuffs and smacked the claws away, but the creature also snapped its mandibles at Catra, who couldn’t jump out of the way fast enough.

“CATRA!” Adora screamed as the Princess disappeared into the bug’s maw. She threw her bag onto the ground and rushed closer to the monster’s body, beating at its stomach to get to her friend. Bow realized he had only a second to make his decision.

He could run, go back to the Horde, tuck into his bunk, and ignore everything that happened. The Rebellion would likely be down a Princess, which would be a victory in itself, and his work liberating the planet would be easier than ever.

But, after everything he had seen, could he really go back and pretend to still be a starry-eyed cadet, unaware of the Horde’s underbelly of destruction? Could he, with all his training to help Etheria and all its inhabitants, turn his back on two people who would likely die with no assistance? Who would he be if he turned a blind eye?

The golden weapon in Adora’s bag glinted as his eyes strayed to it, and he had his answer.

Bow, free of his cuffs, reached into the bag, pulled out the sword, and held it aloft. A flash of light enveloped him and he changed, growing taller and more muscular, his hair flowing well past the required length for cadets. When he finally died down, there was a golden bow in his hand, and he felt a quiver on his back.

The creature stopped fighting Adora and stared transfixed at Bow's new form. Adora turned around and donned a similar expression.

"Who…. who are you?" she asked. The whispering weapon in his hand gave him his answer.

"I am Bow, wielder of the Bow of Protection and Etheria's new She-Ra." He announced. "Though, I would prefer He-Ra, if that's okay with everyone."

Adora was too gobsmacked to answer.

"Great. Now that we've covered that," Bow pulled an arrow out of his quiver, knowing instinctively that it regenerated the second he notched it, and took aim at the bug. "I'm going to need you to cough up the Princess."

Chapter End Notes

> Bow-Ra supremacy right here, because my brand is anyone as She-Ra but Adora! I also straight up made Catra a werecat on accident and I'm not ashamed. Well, they're friends now, so with luck, they can teach each other about how to change into larger more unstable forms. That won't backfire at all.
>
> Hope this sets up the fic for you guys. All the next chapters are going to be out of order snippets from the universe, so don't expect a long cohesive narrative like "What You're Worth". They will also be more Glimbow focused, so Catra and Adora get shifted to the background a lot more than in the opener. It's Glimbow week, so the chaotic bisexuals get more screentime than the disaster gays for once.
> For some generic info on this AU, please check out these fic notes and they should clear up a few things. If you've got a bunch of questions, please ask, responding to comments rules.
>
> Next installment on the 16th and every day after for a week, so look forward to that! Let me know what you think and I'll

see you all then!

Don't You Get It

Chapter Notes

This is short, but sweet, in true Glimbow fashion.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

What is this place ?

Bow opened his eyes and found himself in Halfmoon, staring into the waterfall. He wore the clothes he had always wanted, hair done up in a neat bun. The Heart, Prime, or any signs of the War were gone, including the green veins that had dotted his body seconds ago.

Where was he?

“Catra, get back here!” Bow whirled around at the sound of Glimmer’s voice, seconds before his friends barreled into the room.

“Bow help!” Catra dashed past Bow as Glimmer chased her, waving a hairbrush in the air. “I’m being assaulted by Horde scum!”

“Get her! I’m trying to run a brush through that stupid mane!” Glimmer called as Catra ducked behind Bow.

“Come on, you two.” Adora appeared in the doorway with a gentle smile. Catra darted away from Bow to hid behind her, sticking a tongue out at Glimmer while she pouted at Bow’s side. “I thought we left this behind as kids.”

Bow’s friends were dolled up too. Catra’s hair had grown back out, Adora was wearing a white suit to match her girlfriend’s maroon one, and Glimmer was wearing a dress. That may have been the most unusual part.

“Glimmer started it.” Catra accused playfully.

“You little liar.”

“You’re calling *me* little, Sparkles?”

“Doesn’t matter, I’m finishing it. We need to get ready for the wedding, which means goofing around should be kept to a minimum. Lonnie will kill us if we’re late, you know.” Adora chastised. Catra sighed dramatically and collapsed into Adora’s back. The blonde chuckled and left a kiss on her forehead.

“You two are gross.” Glimmer rolled her eyes.

“Grow up, Sparkles.” Catra got off Adora and headed back into the hallway with Adora close behind. Glimmer went to follow but turned when she noticed Bow had still not said a word.

“Bow?” she asked tentatively. “You coming?” she held out a hand, the fabric of her outfit glinting in the light. Bow had never seen her in a dress before. She looked amazing.

“Of course.” He reached out, but when he touched her hand, he felt nothing but air. The world glitched around him, and when Horde Prime appeared, Bow remembered.

This wasn’t real. It never would be.

“Bow! BOW!” Glimmer screamed at her best friend as he lay dying. The Heart blazed around her, but she didn’t care. If he wasn’t going to make it, then she didn’t want to either. A world without Bow was one she didn’t want to be a part of. “Wake up.”

He didn’t respond. Glimmer put her ear to his chest just to hear his fluttering heartbeat. It was fading fast, but until it was gone, the thumping was her favorite sound.

“You have to get up, Bow. We promised to stay together, no matter what.” Glimmer squeezed her eyes shut, tear falling onto

her friend's shirt. "You can't give up now."

"Too…. late." Bow muttered. Glimmer's eyes shot open, but he was still unconscious. He sounded like he was struggling.

"It's not too late." Glimmer argued. She didn't even know if he could hear her, but she had to try. "You always said it's never too late to do the right thing. If I can do that, after *everything* , then I know you can. All you have to do is wake up."

"I…. failed."

"You could never fail me. Because…." Glimmer took a deep breath. "Because I love you, Bow. I love you."

A bolt of electricity shot straight at her, and Glimmer closed her eyes. She had finally given up her greatest secret. She could evaporate along with the rest of the planet with nothing weighing her down. But the shock never came, and when she looked behind her, she saw an arm holding up a shield, protecting her.

"I love you too." Bow whispered, propping himself up on his elbows. Glimmer looked back at him in disbelief, but it was quickly overwhelmed by happiness. Bow leaned forward, Glimmer leaned down to meet him, and before she knew it, they were kissing. She was living her greatest dream. Despite the near death he had escaped from, Bow's lips were soft and warm, and Glimmer pressed into them happily. A glowing light encased them both, and the world felt right.

It felt whole for the first time. Bow loved her, and that made it all okay.

Chapter End Notes

> I kinda hate that this fic goes straight from the first episode to the last one, but the "confession" prompt worked way too well for "The Heart". I did my best to integrate the Glimbow confession into this scene and I think it turned out pretty good. Their confession is so underrated, honestly.

There's fun post-canon stuff on the way tomorrow, so stay tuned!

Somewhere (Only We Know)

Chapter Notes

> If you're on SPOP Twitter, you probably know where the title came from.
> This one plays fast and loose with "traveling" but I tried, and they're really more guidelines than prompts, so I'm fine.
> Enjoy some cute post-canon

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Ah yes. The King and Queen of Halfmoon.” Glimmer chuckled as the Best Friend Squad shambled into the royal couple’s room. Catra collapsed onto her and Adora’s bed, tail straight in the air, and Adora faceplanted into an armchair. “‘Your Majesties, the royal butt-kisser needs your attention at once.’”

“I will end you, Sparkles.” Catra threatened weakly, lifting her head from her pillow to growl.

“That would require standing, Fur Face.” Glimmer rolled her eyes.

“Called my bluff. Curse you.”

“Glimmer, leave them alone. It’s tough being royalty.” Bow said lightly. Adora let out a muffled groan. “I’m sure all that curtsying really took it out of them.”

“I hate you both.” Catra sighed. “I’m the Queen, I can have you both banished.”

“Don’t banish them, love.” Adora rebuked, head still firmly in the cushion while her knees rested on the carpet.

“You can’t tell me what to do.”

“We’re married, and I’m a King, so technically, I can.”

“Queens outrank Kings. Haven’t you ever played chess?”

“Why don’t we leave the happy couple to it and head to our own bed?” Bow suggested quietly as his friends bickered tiredly.

“Best idea I’ve heard all night.” Glimmer agreed.

“See you two tomorrow for the next round of the conference.” Bow called over his shoulder, announcing his departure.

“What time does the skiff leave again?” Catra asked.

“Moonrise.” Glimmer said cheerfully. Both royals groaned.

“I wish we were still at War,” Adora muttered. “Then I could go back to punching things instead of shaking hands with the planet’s snottiest nobles.”

“We can always punch them.” Catra suggested.

“No, we shouldn’t. It’s frowned upon.”

“Damn social convention.”

“Agreed.”

“Goodnight, guys.” Bow slipped out and grabbed Glimmer by the wrist while he sneakily escaped.

“What’s so good about it?” Catra grumbled as the door closed behind Bow.

“They’re adjusting to their roles well.” Glimmer sighed. “Did Catra struggle with being Queen this much before? I feel like that may have made my job easier if this is how things always were.”

“Yeah, being Queen during a war is a lot different than peacetime. Now that it’s over and her focuses are on more minor stuff like trade routes and taxes, it’s been an adjustment.” Bow reasoned. “The marriage and Adora officially becoming King helped her balance the load, but Adora can only do so much.”

"Thank goodness for Felina." Without Catra's long-lost mother doing the bulk of the behind-the-scenes work of running Halfmoon, the kingdom would have surely devolved into anarchy.

"They'll get the hang of it. Adora's very organized. She'll be a great King with a little time." Bow trusted his friends with his life, if a little less with an entire land of lives. Adora was sure to take to leadership well, and Catra could be responsible when she needed to be. It would work out.

"So, if they're the King and Queen of Halfmoon, what do you think that makes us? Princess of the Fright Zone and Prince of Power? Doesn't exactly roll off the tongue." Glimmer pushed open the door to their room.

"Thinking about tomorrow?" Bow deciphered. The journey to the reclaimed Fright Zone was easily the most anticipated part of their tour. Adora and Catra were excited to see the old battleground as friendly territory for the first time, but Glimmer seemed to only feel dread. She didn't know where she stood with the place, and Bow didn't have a clue either. "You know no one is making you take over? Whatever you want to claim or disown about your kingdom is your business."

"I don't know, Bow." Glimmer admitted, sitting hard on the bed. "It's all so….. political. Adora has the right idea about punching things."

"The Fright Zone…. *Brightmoon* ….. is your birthright. Yours to claim or reject. No one will judge you if you don't want ownership of it because of all those horrible memories."

"Of course people will judge me."

"I won't. I know Catra and Adora won't. None of our friends will, and who cares what anyone else thinks."

"I guess I'm still on the fence about this. I mean, it's *my* kingdom. That just feels so strange." Glimmer hugged herself,

and Bow hugged her too. “Maybe I gave Catra too much flak. This royalty business is pretty stressful.”

“Catra’s a drama queen, now more literally than ever.” Bow laughed. “This is just the hard part. Whatever you decide, I’ll stand with you.”

“I know.” Glimmer nodded.

“I love you.”

“I love you too.” they kissed briefly, and Bow released his girlfriend. He could tell she needed a little space. “Thank you, Bow.”

“You don’t need to thank me. I’m just being a good boyfriend.”

“I want to thank you.”

“Well, in that case, you’re very welcome.” Bow stood up from the bed. “I’m going to go for a little walk, maybe check in on the bluebloods. Do you want anything?”

“I’m alright.”

“I’ll bring you the most beautiful flowers I can find.”

“Plumeria has a lot of flowers.”

“I’ll have to choose wisely then.” Bow grinned and headed out the door. “See you in a bit.”

“Yeah. I just need a little time to think.”

“I know, Glimmer. Take all the time you need.”

……

“No matter how many times I come to the Fright Zone, I just can’t believe you guys grew up here.” Adora ran a hand along the Fright Zone’s walls as the Best Friend Squad walked along. “It’s so….”

“Dank.” Catra supplied, kicking a piece of rubble with her foot. “I don’t know how you didn’t figure out that the Horde was evil sooner when you lived in a place like this.”

“Oh, I knew it was evil. It was obvious.” Glimmer shrugged. “I just didn’t care.”

“Ah, not caring. I can relate.” Catra agreed.

“It took me some adjusting time, but in hindsight, I should have known.” Bow admitted.

“How did you ever have a proper childhood in a place like this?” Adora wondered.

“We didn’t.” Bow said. “But we had each other, so there were plenty of good memories to counter the bad.

“Softy.” Glimmer rolled her eyes.

“Your softy.” He leaned down to peck her on the lips and she grabbed his neck and pulled him in for a full kiss. Catra made gagging noises in the background, but Bow didn’t care.

“Could you not suck face right now? You two have a room, you know.” Catra grumbled when they broke apart.

“We do? I haven’t noticed.” Glimmer shrugged. “Besides, we’re enjoying our recently-dating honeymoon period. We have license to make out wherever.”

“That’s not how that works, Glimmer.” Bow countered, his girlfriend’s hands still around his neck.

“Yeah, silly us. We wasted our honeymoon period on a war.” Catra said. “We could have just waited until the world almost ended like you two geniuses.”

“It was nice. We got to do fun war things as a couple.” Adora offered.

“Like stabbing.” Catra mimicked a stabbing motion and grinned. “I do love to stab things.”

“That’s funny. I thought it was Adora that likes stabbing.” Glimmer said offhandedly. Adora turned bright red and Catra started choking. Bow coughed to cover a chuckle.

“Remind me why you aren’t in jail if you’re just going to roast my wife and me?” Catra choked out.

“I can teleport, good luck arresting me.”

“You’re so bad at, though.”

“How about we *don’t* arrest our friends, huh?” Bow offered, clapping his hands. “Let’s let everything be under the bridge.”

“It’s under, Bow, don’t worry. I’m just kidding around.” Catra promised. “Though, I could arrest you both for the little public indecency back there.”

“Actually, this isn’t your kingdom, Catra. So really, I should be the one threatening you.” Glimmer crossed her arms.

“It’s nobody’s kingdom right now. Not until it’s claimed or relinquished.” Adora said, taking her hand from the wall.

“Right.” Glimmer muttered, some of the air sucked from the room.

“Have you given any thought to that?” Adora asked.

“Have I ever. But no, I haven’t decided yet if that’s what you’re asking.”

“Well, there’s no pressure.”

“There’s actually quite a lot of pressure. The official declaration of the kingdom’s standing is in a few hours. I need to have made my decision by then.” Glimmer rephrased.

“Yes, well-”

“Adora, love, please stop talking.” Catra laced their hands and gave her wife a pointed look. Adora seemed to get the hint and changed her expression to a somewhat exaggerated smirk.

“Is that an order, My Queen?” she squeezed Catra’s hand, and Catra swallowed hard, clearly not expecting the tone of the conversation to switch over so fast.

“Maybe.” She caught on and matched Adora’s smile.

“Hmmm, what if I don’t feel like following orders?”

“And we’ve circled back to gross.” Glimmer groaned, though Bow could tell she was happy for the subject change.

“Anything’s better than awkward.” Bow shrugged.

“Speak for yourself.” Glimmer said. The pair of couple’s turned the corner, and Glimmer’s eyes widened. Bow looked up and saw what she was staring at. “Is that-”

“Our place.” Bow confirmed. Not so far away stood the tower they always climbed as kids, looking the same aside from some foliage wrapped around the base. “It’s still here.”

“I thought I would have pummeled it when I pummeled Hordak.”

“Yeah, you trashed everything else.” Catra added.

“I wonder what it looks like from up there now, with everything changed.” Glimmer mused.

“Catra, didn’t you want to show me the Moonstone chamber.” Adora elbowed her wife in the ribs.

“OW- I mean, yeah.” She nodded vigorously. “I want to go spit on the place where Light Spinner tortured me.”

“Your version of closure is so strange.” Adora shook her head.

“It’s a cat thing.” Catra promised, pulling Adora down the hallway to their right.

“Sure.” Adora’s voice disappeared down the hall, and Bow and Glimmer continued staring.

“Do you want to go up there? I’m not sure if the stairs are still standing.” Bow said after a long moment.

“Actually, I have a better plan.” Glimmer shrugged out of her jacket and flared her wings. She kept them hidden for the most part, but they were bigger every time Bow saw them.

“Are you sure?” Bow leaned away slightly. If Glimmer’s teleports were bad, her flying was to be feared.

“It’ll be fun to get a bird’s eye view of the place.” Glimmer swore, stretching the appendages out some.

“Well, if you think it’s safe-”

“That’s a yes, you consented!” Glimmer grabbed Bow around the waist and rocketed into the air, leaving Bow’s heart behind on the ground.

…….

“It’s hard to imagine this place filled with people. It’s been empty for almost a year.” Bow smoothed his hair back and sat down, tangling his feet over the edge like they did as kids. Glimmer took her spot by his side, propping one foot up on the platform and resting her head on her knee. “Everyone jumped ship after Prime arrived.”

“No, they were leaving before then.” Glimmer admitted. “After Salineas, I tripled all the shifts to try and maintain the momentum we had gained. More often than not, when I sent soldiers into the field, they just….. left. Saw their opportunity to jump ship and get away from my crazy expectations of them.”

“Is that why the attack on Animalia failed?” Bow was hesitant to ask about Glimmer’s time as a warlord, but if she brought it up first, it felt less invasive to talk about.

“Maybe. I don’t think people’s hearts were in it anymore. After Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio left to join you guys, morale plummeted. That, plus Double Trouble’s backstab and the boast the Heart I accidentally gave the other Princesses, the odds just weren’t with me.” Glimmer said. “I think it’s okay, though. If I had won, we wouldn’t be here. We wouldn’t be together, and the world wouldn’t be the better place it is.”

“I agree. I think this is the best possible outcome, if you don’t mind me saying.”

“I could have done without the chipping, but yeah, things really worked out.” She stared out over the trees that had regrown around the Fright Zone. “I can’t imagine destroying this. Sometimes I can’t even remember why I ever wanted it all to burn.”

“You were hurting.” Bow said.

“That doesn’t make it right.”

“I know. But it does make it easier to forgive, I guess. You weren’t destroying selfishly, like Hordak, or for the sake of it, like Prime. It’s been a long road to get where we are, and you aren’t the only one who hit a lot of bumps along the way, even if they were somewhat larger than mine.”

“You never tried to destroy the world.”

“You never almost did.” Bow remembered the feeling of power surging through the Sword of Protection before he shattered it. It was awe-inspiring and terrifying, exhilarating and painful. He could feel himself leaching from the planet, see it crumbling under him. In his mind, Bow was the person who had come the closest to destroying everything. “Besides, I would argue a good bit of the Heart fiasco is on Catra and Light Hope.”

“And DT, for that matter. I have to say, convincing me to connect to the Moonstone and omitting that the Heart would power the other Princess’s was pretty underhanded.”

“This is DT we’re talking about. ‘Underhanded’ is more than accurate.” Bow recalled

“Has anyone heard from them at all since the Underwater Gala?”

“Last I heard, Huntara invited them back to the Wastes. They used some of their cash to fund a theater for the place, citing its ‘lack of culture,’ but I just think they want to put on and star in some productions.”

“Double Trouble used to tell me it was their dream to have a theater.” Glimmer nodded. “It’s nice that they’re living the life they want.”

“Anything to keep them out of espionage.” Bow chuckled. “They were far too good at it. They could have dragged out the charade a lot longer if Catra didn’t sniff them out.”

“Speaking of sniffing out, I got the strangest letter from Spinnerella.” Glimmer snapped her fingers and looked at him. “She and Netossa are opening an aromatherapy business in Plumeria when their pardons go through.”

“I’m glad they’re acclimating to civilian life so well.” Bow said. “I heard Juliet is applying to be a teacher in Halfmoon. A few former-Horde teaching about the War will be a nice balance, I think, especially since Halfmoon wasn’t in the War for so long. Most of the citizens aren’t all that well-versed.”

“You really like Halfmoon, don’t you?” Glimmer asked.

“I mean, it’s where my friends are. The place itself is nice enough, but it’s the company that I love.”

“So, if I decided to move here and be Princess, would you come with me?” Glimmer’s voice was quiet and pointedly stared into the

distance.

“You don’t need to worry about that. That shouldn’t be a factor in your decision.”

“Of course it should!” she turned to him. “Bow, I love you, and I want us to be happy, and if my taking this mantle will affect that, then-”

“Whatever you decide, I’ll be there, and I’ll be happy because we’re together.” He took her hand. “I went across the universe to find you. I’m not leaving, not unless you ask me to.”

“I would never.”

“Then you’re stuck with me.” he leaned forward and kissed her forehead. “Always.”

“I could never be stuck with you. Every second of us together is a treasure. This place,” Glimmer gestured with the hand not in Bow’s to the Fright Zone. “Terrible as it was, it gave us that.”

“I guess there’s a little beauty everywhere.” Bow mused. The Fright Zone itself had sprouted when he released the magic. Not as much as everywhere else, but enough so that the once barren soil was dotted with grass and flowers, the very tower they sat on covered in weeds.

“That beauty needs to be cultivated by someone who knows what they’re doing.” Glimmer whispered. Bow whipped his head to stare at his girlfriend. “Someone who’s less of a screwup.”

“Glimmer, you’re not-”

“Bow, nearly every moment we lived in the Fright Zone was hell, but the time I had with you was a gift. I think….. I think we shouldn’t expect any more from this place.” she finally stopped staring off into the distance and looked down at where she was. “I think it’s given us everything it has to offer.”

Bow thought for a moment while Glimmer squeezed his hand and took in the Fright Zone below her.

“Okay.” He said after a minute. She looked up. “I agree. It’s time to put this place behind us.”

“I’m ready to find a paradise and live in it with you.” Glimmer gave him a watery smile. “Somewhere out there is the perfect place for us. Maybe it’s in Halfmoon, or the Woods, or gods-forbid Plumeria, but it’s there. Waiting for us.”

“Until then, wherever we’re together is home.” Bow promised.

“Sap.” Glimmer chuckled with a fond smile.

“Your sap. Forever.”

“I like the sound of that.”

Chapter End Notes

> Winged-Glimmer Supremacy! Also, if you can't tell, Glimmer and Catra's banter is some of my favorite to write in fanfics. I am in no way a Glitra shipper, but I can see why people do. They've got a good repertoire for me to work with. Tomorrow, Princess Prom! Get psyched yall, it's gonna be great. Let me know what you think of this fun chap and tune in tomorrow for the first we see of actually-antagonistic Glimmer.

Prom Gone Wrong

Chapter Notes

> I realized the line about the Moonstone Chamber from yesterday probably didn't make sense. This one helps clear that up a little. Also, quick reminder for the first chapter that Halfmoon is NEUTRAL in the War until Catra becomes Queen and Scorpia's Kingdom is the closest equivalent to Brightmoon. That's relevant here.
> Princess Prom, baby! Plenty of ships today, since there are some Catradora moments to intersperse the Glimbow, just like the canon version. Plus, y'all get to see Horde Glimmer for the first time. Exciting stuff all around. Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Deep breaths, Catra , she reminded herself. Still, the sight of Adora with that other Princess was enough to rile her up beyond what her anger management techniques could help.

"-believe she just showed up here. And with Spinnerella and Netossa of all people?" Bow was talking, but Catra was too busy burying her claws into the banister. "How did they even get an inv- Are you okay?" Catra startled as Bow put a hand on her wrist.

"I'm fine."

"You're not fine. Do you want to tell me what's wrong?" Bow pressed. Catra sighed and tore her gaze away from Adora and Mermista to look at her friend.

"Not really."

"Sure. And the fact that you've been glaring at Mermista all night doesn't mean anything."

"I just can't believe she invited Adora to Prom. She knows Adora is my friend." Catra could feel the fur on her back rising up. That

wasn't a good sign.

"People can have multiple friends, Catra."

"I know that. But Adora and I…. it's always been just us. Most of the other kids in the village would never talk to me because of my status, and the ones that did just wanted something. Adora's the only person I've ever met who doesn't care about all that." *I can't lose her.*

"I think you're being a little irrational." Bow said gently.

"You think?!"

"Adora has the right to hang out with other people. Besides, you're the one who's been avoiding her all night. I'm sure she just came here with Mermista so I could come with you." he reasoned. "You and I should go down there and hang out with them both. See Scorpia and Perfuma are here, even Entrapta. It could be a whole Alliance hangout."

"Please, we both know you're going to be on Glimmer-watch all night. Why are you even lecturing me when you're just as bad?" Catra accused with a snarl. Bow's expression hardened.

"Okay, you're upset, but that is not an excuse to take it out on me." he stated firmly. Catra sighed and loosened her grip a little.

"You're right. I'm sorry."

"Glad to hear it. Now, since you brought it up, I think keeping an eye on the *Horde spies* in our midst is a great idea. I'll take Glimmer." Bow said.

"Oh, I bet you will." Catra coughed.

"Why are you like this?"

"Go get Sparkles, I'll keep on an eye on the milfs."

“Catra, never talk again.”

“Do we have a plan or not?” Catra pressed.

“Hopefully, that will help keep your mind off Adora, since apparently just talking with her isn’t happening.” Bow raised an eyebrow.

“We can talk later. I don’t want to make a scene at a Ball.” Catra waved off the concern.

“That worried about shifting, huh?” Bow picked up.

“Don’t be ridiculous.”

“I told you not to leave your mask at the coat check.”

“And I told you that it’s a magical item and technically not allowed under All-Princess-Ball rules. Didn’t you read the invite?”

“Did I ever.”

“Go chase your ex around, golden boy.” Catra got up and unceremoniously left the conversation, making a beeline for the hallway. Maybe she could beg the guard for her mask back. The magical energy that controlled her powers would probably help quell some of her harsher emotions.

The hallways seemed unnecessarily long and the cold only annoyed her further. Catra ran her hand along the wall just to feel something as the edges of her vision started to lose their color. Reverting to color-blindness was a sure sign that a transformation was creeping up on her. She had to hurry.

“Well, hello there, sweetie. What are you doing so far from the party?” the pink-haired woman who came with Glimmer was in the hallway, standing by an unmarked door. “Looking for the bathroom?”

“Get out of my way, Horde. I need to get to the coat check.” Catra growled. She took a deep breath and dug her slightly extended claws into her palms. The woman’s eyes flickered to her now-bleeding hands.

“I don’t know where the coat check is, but we can try to find it together if you want.” She offered. “You seem a little stressed.”

“I’m gonna be a lot more stressed if you don’t get out of my way NOW.” Catra threatened.

“Ma’am, excuse me.” one of the guards working the event, some twiggy blonde boy, came up behind her. “Are you lost?” she whirled around, startled.

“Where is the coat check? I need my items immediately.” Catra turned back to the woman, but she was gone. Did she go through the door, and if so, where did it go? She was supposed to be keeping an eye on this woman, after all.

“I’m sorry, but all things surrendered at the door can’t be taken back until the end of the night.” The guard said.

“You don’t understand!” she grabbed him by the shoulders. “I need my mask back, or we’ll both have a massive problem on our hands! Tell me where the coat check is!”

“Calm down, Princess. I’m just doing my job.” The guard’s voice quaked, and Catra didn’t have the brainpower to question why such an easily cowed character was protecting a powerful monarch.

“I’ll find it myself then!” she started back down the hallway, but the purple lamps dotting the hallway turned blue and her legs trembled as she walked. She was out of time.

“Are you alright?” the guard chased her, cutting her off right in front of the door the Horde woman went through. “Who did you come here with, maybe they can help?”

And that was it. Catra snarled, and the guard yelped, pushing her away from him. She fell back and hit the ground on all fours, the remains of her nice suit dotting the icy floor.

Irritant . She locked onto the guard, her devolved animal brain recognizing him as the cause of her shifting, but before she could charge, the door opened. The guard took several steps back and a net barreled out of the open door, knocking Catra against the wall and entangling her.

"Boom, nets!" The other woman Glimmer had arrived with came out into the hall and closed the door behind her. "Way to get her in position, Kyle. Right by the door."

"Thank you, Force Captain." The guard nodded. Catra snarled and thrived in the glowing net, but the woman seemed more amused than scared like Kyle had been. She a stun baton from out of her concealed ankle holster and whirled it between her fingers.

"Game over, kitty." She charged it to full power, and Catra's eyes widened. "Nighty night."

"Have you seen Catra?" Adora sounded on the edge of panic as she pulled Bow away from his pursuit of Glimmer and demanded his attention.

"She went to the coat check for her mask. Her powers were acting up a little." Bow said soothingly. Adora didn't look convinced.

"I saw her head for the hallway, but that was an hour ago." She waved her hands a little like she did when she was upset. Had it really been an hour? Bow supposed he could have lost track of time pursuing Glimmer. Come to think of it, he hadn't seen Spinnerella or Netossa in a while either…..

"Did you see the couple who came with Glimmer at any point in the past hour?" he asked.

“No, but I wasn’t exactly looking. Mermista was telling this story, and I was focused on her, and then Entrapta wanted me to help her measure trash can fullness levels, and then-”

“So Catra’s been gone an hour and both Force Captains she came with are nowhere to be seen?” Bow was putting two and two together, and it wasn’t looking good.

“Well, when you put it that way, it almost sounds like-” Adora stopped. “Oh no.”

“We have to-”

“And now, the first dance of the Ball.” Frosta announced the lights dimmed, and someone whisked Adora away as the music started. When the spotlights came on, Glimmer stood by Bow’s side, hand outstretched.

“What have you done, Glimmer?” Bow narrowed his eyes. Glimmer only smiled.

“Harsh accusations, Bow. I came under the laws of hospitality. Would I really risk getting thrown out of my first party just to pull some ill-conceived stunt?” she shook her head.

“You were never one for missing an opportunity.” Bow remembered. “A high-level gathering that you can easily infiltrate? Why pass it up?”

“Maybe I’m just here so Spinnerella and Netossa can connect with their Princess roots.”

“Their what?” they spun away from each other as Glimmer merely winked at his question.

“Perfuma and Scorpia haven’t seen Catra or Glimmer’s posse. This is bad.” Adora grabbed Bow’s hand, and they resumed dancing. “Catra would never leave a party without telling me. Or you!”

“I think something’s happened. Glimmer’s being….. suspicious, and the fact that no one has seen her chaperones isn’t helping. When we get a minute, we’ll break off the dancing and go look for her.” Bow planned. Adora nodded as they separated.

“Oh hey, Bow!” Scorpia greeted. “You know, I was just telling Perfuma that we haven’t seen enough of you tonight. Since you’re going back to Halfmoon tonight, I kind of thought the Alliance would get to spend a little more time with She, er, He-Ra before your break.”

“I know, Scorpia, I’m sorry. And we’re only going back to Halfmoon for Queen C’yra’s birthday. Catra needs to be with her mom, but it won’t be a break. Adora and I were planning on scouting some of the closer Horde bases.” Bow reiterated, veering on defensive. Scorpia didn’t mean anything by her comments, but every time Adora, Catra, and he went back to Catra’s village for a little bit, someone in the Rebellion made snide comments about ‘their commitment.’ He was just tired of the insinuation.

“Oh, sweet! You know, if you’re at a Horde base, Entrapta needs a six-sided hex driver and a Horde bot power-core.” Scorpia said excitedly.

“I’ll see what I can do.” He whirled back to Adora, who was looking paler after her brief dance with Glimmer.

“We have to go. Now.” She insisted.

“But it’s the first dance. It would be incredibly rude.” Bow reminded her. Adora shook her head.

“You know I’m all about etiquette, but-” a hand tightly gripped Bow’s shoulder and pulled him away. He turned around to find Glimmer had resumed her place as his partner.

“What did you tell her?” he asked immediately, delving into his manners reserves to continue dancing.

"Oh, nothing much. Just about all the fun things Light Spinner has planned for her furry friend once we're done here. I don't know what part of that rattled her." Glimmer shrugged.

"So that's your plan? A kidnapping on neutral ground, and a Princess from a neutral kingdom, no less? Do you have any idea how poorly that reflects on you?" Bow said.

"I haven't the slightest idea what you're talking about. *I* haven't done anything, let alone kidnapped someone. That's quite the accusation."

"Don't play dumb, Glimmer!" Bow shoved Glimmer away from him, pushing her into an ice table and startling the crowd. "Tell me what you did!" he stalked toward her, and the guests parted anxiously.

"Like I said, I haven't done a thing. Netossa, on the other hand, was assisting your Princess friend with some free electroshock therapy last I heard. Maybe that will help control with those *explosive* anger issues." Bow grabbed Glimmer by the collar and she raised an eyebrow, unfazed.

"Where is Catra?" he demanded, uncharacteristically angry.

"She could be halfway to the Fright Zone by now."

"If you hurt her-"

"Oh please, Bow. That tough-guy act may work on grunts, but we were raised together. I know you never hit an unarmed opponent." Glimmer rolled her eyes, still hoisted above Bow's head with ease.

"That was before you hurt my friends."

"If that sets you off, you're really in for it now." As if on cue, wind barreled into the ballroom, battering the pillars and throwing chunks of ice across the room. Bow dropped Glimmer in surprise

and she immediately pulled a potion from inside her dress, smashed it on the floor, and vanished.

"What's happening?" Adora ran up to Bow, hands over her head to protect from falling ice chunks. She yelled over the howling winds while Bow grabbed onto the broken table to keep from being blown over.

"They've got Catra! Go find her, and I'll catch up. I need to locate Glimmer!" he directed over the chaos. Adora nodded and struggled through the galls towards the direction Catra vanished.

Bow let go and let himself be blown across the floor, eventually getting to the other hallway and slamming the door shut, blocking out the air. He ran through the Palace, searching, and found her on the roof before long.

"Did you like Spinnerella's surprise?" Glimmer asked, facing away from him to overlook the ledge before her.

"Why are you doing this?" Bow demanded.

"You of all people should know how those two never pass up a challenge. After all, you spent so much time with them during your *special training,* preparing to leave me behind. A whole lot of nothing that did you." Glimmer said.

"I never wanted to leave you behind. I wanted to fight for the good guys, and I wanted us to do it together. It isn't too late, Glimmer." Bow tried. "But if you hurt my friends, I will have to fight you." he slowly walked toward her.

"I was your friend."

"This is your chance to still be." He offered, halfway across the roof. "Tell me where Catra is." Glimmer laughed once, humorlessly.

"You want to lecture me about how we can still be friends when the only reason you're talking to me is to get info about that *Princess* ?" she hissed, turning around. Bow winced at the anger

in her eyes and stopped. “If you really cared about me, you would come back to the Horde, be a good guy by changing things from the inside. But no. All you care about is your precious new identity and all those cheering people who adore He-Ra so much.”

“Glimmer-”

“You built yourself a new life, with shiny new friends to replace your old ones, and you want me to believe that you can find a place in it for me?” she threw her hands in the air as she spoke, and Bow took a few defiant steps forward.

“That’s not what I’m doing!” he rebuked, nearly close enough to reach her now.

“Then save your empty offers. I don’t need your pity. With you gone, I can finally take my place at the top like I deserve!” she grinned maniacally.

“I’m not giving up on you, Glimmer.” Bow said, reaching out a hand to his oldest friend. “There’s good in you, but if you don’t let it out, you’ll fall too far.”

“Well then.” Her expression softened, but the gleam in her eye was still there. Bow started to retract his hand, but it was too late. “I’ll just have to take you down with me!” she seized his wrist and leaned back, pitching them both off the side of the roof.

Bow woke up outside the ballroom, the castle’s damage from the attack repaired. He was lightly buoying in some water as Mermista maneuvered him gently through the window he was outside of and onto the ground. The Alliance gathered around him, staring with worried eyes. But two people were missing.

“Where’s Adora?” he croaked. Perfuma and Mermista exchanged a look, and that was the answer he needed.

Catra’s eyes fluttered open, pain consuming everything. The world was tinged gray, a shade she knew from experience was actually purple. When her sight focused, she instantly noticed that she was in a cage. She instinctually threw herself against the bars and they stung her. With a yelp, she jumped away from them, only to run into the bars on her other side.

She stumbled over her paws, trying to balance so she didn’t hit against any of the stinging bars. She was tired, much more exhausted than she could stand in her cat form, but when she tried to change, the bars reached out and zapped her without her even touching them.

“I would refrain from using your savage magic if I were you.” a voice said from the shadows. A woman in dark robes with a cloth over the lower half of her face seemed to materialize from the darkness itself. “I’m afraid your powers and my Moonstone aren’t very compatible. But then again, I’m so curious how it will affect you, so feel free to struggle further.”

Catra snarled at the woman and surged forward, but the magical barrier stopped her again, sending a shockwave through her entire body and forcing her onto her knees. Panting, Catra looked up at the woman as she loomed over the cage, eyes suggesting a menacing grin.

“Welcome to the Fright Zone, Princess.”

Chapter End Notes

First glimpse of Light Spinner instead of Shadow Weaver. They're both pretty evil, honestly. Catra and Adora have reason to hate her in every universe.
The conflict that follows this one is that Entrapta gets left behind rescuing Catradora and Catra is stuck as a cat from exposure to the Moonstone. The Queen isn't happy when she finds out and Bow goes out to the Woods to develop his healing magic. I have plenty of ideas for the shenanigans the BFS could get into trying to hide the fact that Catra can't

shift, but that's a one-shot for another day. This week is just for Glimbow.
This is one of my fav chapters, so let me know what you thought and I'll see you all tomorrow!

I Know You

Chapter Notes

> More season 4 exposition! Not exactly the most fun topic, but y'all seemed interested in the little lore drops from previous chapters, so you'll probably like this one.
> Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“I’m going to kill her.” Adora groaned, sifting through the wreck of the Fright Zone. She found a piece of tech and shoved it in her pocket next to the two halves of Catra’s helmet. “First, I’m going to kill Horde Prime for daring to kidnap her, and then I’ll kill her for not listening to me!”

“I feel like murder shouldn’t be high on your list of fun reuniting activities.” Bow reminded, sorting through his own pile. Tech scavenging was more challenging than the Horde-Trio made it look. Then again, he probably had it even easier than them since all the tech was concentrated in one place. “I mean, we’re building a ship almost from scratch to save her, only for you to kill her the second we get her out of danger?”

“Yeah, we’re going to save Catra, but that doesn’t mean I’m not still pissed. She could have gotten all of us killed.”

“Is this about the stunt with DT again?” Bow raised an eyebrow. It had been nearly a month, but Adora wasn’t getting any less upset.

“I just can’t believe she would go behind our backs like that.” Adora sulked, folding her arms. “She should have trusted us more.”

“Not to play Horde-Lord’s advocate, but she was trying to help. I’m feeling untrusted too, but she did what she did for a good reason.” Bow didn’t think Adora was as mad she claimed, or

maybe she was even madder. Her mood had been fluctuating wildly since Prime arrived, and he was not great at reading grieving people.

"I know. But I don't know if that makes it forgivable or not. Catra pulled Queen card on us, and I know she hated when C'yra-" Adora stopped, and Bow winced. "She shouldn't have done that, is all." she seemed to cool down a little, the memory of the lost queen reminding her *why* Catra did what she did. Why the Heart had seemed worth it, despite every warning to the contrary.

"Being the leader is hard work, and while I agree that Catra kinda betrayed our trust, I can't really hold it against her. Much less threaten regicide."

"I'm her girlfriend, I can kill her if I want. Adora pouted.

The Fright Zone was full of valuable things, at least Adora thought so, and the Etherian Horde didn't really exist anymore, so they didn't need it. They should mean more fun toys for the Rebellion, but so far, Adora and Entrapta hadn't been able to make many strides with Darla. Tensions heightened every day the ship wasn't complete, mostly because Adora radiated anxiety about what Catra could be going through on Prime's ship. She was alone up there, and Adora was ready to drive everyone crazy by reminding them whenever it was brought up.

"The day you kill Catra is the day Scorpia and I announce our engagement." Bow rolled his eyes. "Murder is still wrong, remember. You taught me that when I left the Horde, remember? Practice what you preach." Bow shrugged, sealing up the bag filled with debris.

"I'm serious." Adora said. "I will murder her for scaring me like this."

"Please, you'll both be so happy to see each other that I'll be lucky to get out of the way before the making out starts."

"I don't know about making out, Bow. I'm not ready to get over what happened yet. We're her best friends, and I'm her girlfriend. She shouldn't have treated us like that." Adora tossed a piece of concrete over the decimated wall on her left. It sailed over and disappeared. "I want to forgive her, but I just don't know how. I'm *always* the bigger person, but I'm gonna need a pretty big apology for a stunt like this, or….." she trailed off.

"Forgiveness is tough, I know." Bow looked around at where they were. The Fright Zone, specifically the Moonstone Chamber. So many horrible memories in this room, some more recent and raw than others. He was almost glad to see it in shambles. "Sometimes, I feel I'm too forgiving."

He thought Light Spinner's final moments as she lay dying, far beyond the help of He-Ra's healing magic. She had asked him if he resented her, and in the heat of the moment, he had said no. He didn't want to tell her off while in her final moments, but sometimes, he regretted holding back. She died thinking she was forgiven, believing that her actions that made he and Glimmer's lives terrible were just water under the bridge.

A small, angry part of him didn't think she deserved the small amount of peace that might have brought her.

" *Too* forgiving? I wouldn't say that." Adora looked up from the pile of wires she was sorting through to give Bow a worried look. "Especially not about you. You're not a doormat, or whatever you're thinking, just a really decent person. You see the best in people."

"I guess I was just raised wrong. I don't feel like I have the right to be angry at people."

"You always have the right to be angry. You have the right to never forgive someone if they piss you off enough. It's all your decision." Adora shrugged. "If someone wants forgiveness, they have to work for it, you know? If they aren't sorry, you don't owe

them anything. Just remember that keeping grudges is bad for your health."

"So you're really not forgiving Catra for the Heart?" Bow frowned.

"Of course I'm forgiving her. I don't want to speak for you, but chances are, you will too." Adora looked back down at the pile of scraps at her feet. "I know where she was coming from, even if ordering us around and going behind my back wasn't okay. I still love her, and I want to work past all that if she's willing to make it up to me. But I'm gonna need one heck of an apology first, I guess in a non-murder fashion since you disapprove."

Bow sighed and fiddled with the bag at his feet.

"Friendship is hard enough. I imagine dating is serious work."

"You have to work at it, just like anything else. But when you love someone, and it's worth it, then the work is doable." Adora said it so confidently like it was simple. Bow had never known love to be simple. He found love and lost it again so many times within these destroyed halls, and not once had it been easy.

If it wasn't easy, then that left him with a very complicated question. Is it worth it?

Darla sputtered through space, but Bow wasn't paying much attention to that. The world boiled down to this room, just him and Glimmer. Catra and Adora making out in the next room, forgiveness not yet awarded but on its way, didn't exist. Entrapta fiddling with the circuits, hopefully no important ones, didn't exist. Space itself and Horde Prime's looming threat didn't exist.

Just Bow and Glimmer, laying on the cot in the engine room in silence. The tiny wings she had gained after forging a connection with the Moonstone poked his pecs, and his breath on her new scar from the chip couldn't be comfortable. None of that mattered, though. Glimmer was in his arms, and she had turned

her back on the Horde. She had been given a choice and she chose good, like he always knew she could.

What he *didn't* think she could was apologize. He was sure that she was sorry, but a full-blown apology was something Glimmer had never given him until just a few days ago. And then she said it again once he rescued her. She apologized over and over with words and actions, but never requested forgiveness.

This was what Adora had meant when she told him about grudges. Glimmer was putting in the work, and she had a long way to go, but the groundwork was all there. From here on in, she would work be better. But she didn't expect his forgiveness, nor did she need it or even bring it up. Bow was well within his rights to hold Glimmer to her worst moments and not forgive her.

She had done so much evil, brought him and Etheria itself so much pain.

And yet, despite all the evidence telling him that Glimmer deserved prison or worse, his decision seemed so clear.

It would take a long time for everything to be forgiven between them, for both of their deeds to be water under the bridge. But, until then, Bow closed his eyes and banished the thoughts of the person she was in the Horde. He focused on the Glimmer in his arms, the one with new scars and a fresh perspective brought on by her recent and temporary demise. She was absolutely worth forgiving.

Glimmer was worth it.

Chapter End Notes

> I'm not sure how happy I am with this one. It was probably the hardest to write, just from the perspective of having to tackle this pretty complicated subject. SPOP canon does this better, obviously, but I feel like I did okay. I'm about the opposite of a grudge holder, so what I wanted was for everyone to immediately forgive each other, but that's not

how it works, really. It needed to be more realistic than that. Hope you liked this one. Pissed-off Adora was pretty fun, and I feel like Bow is a little OOC, but he's forgiving in the canon too, so I'm alright with it. Let me know what you think and I'll see you tomorrow for the first chapter from Glimmer's perspective!

Rest At Long Last

Chapter Notes

> This thing got way too big and was also the only chapter I hadn't written to prior to the day of posting. So, if this is a day late, no it's not. It's still yesterday somewhere, I'm sure.
>
> This chap is all Glimmer and almost entirely lore. Sadly, all the Glimbow is at the end. Sorry, Tippen... Still, you guys wanna see how the fright Zone got destroyed?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Glimmer didn't need sleep. She needed to win, and that victory was so close.

"Force Captain Glimmer." Spinnerella ran to catch up as Glimmer stalked through the halls of the Fright Zone. Netossa made her way towards them at a walking pace. "I have a few reports for you to-"

"Are the troops on their way?" Glimmer interrupted. Spinny shifted in front of Glimmer, blocking her path.

"Well….. yes."

"That's all I need to know."

"Glimmer, there are some very pressing reports coming from the front lines." Spinnerella insisted.

"Whatever it is, give me a minute and I can handle it."

"But the Rebellion-"

"Is in shambles, remember?" Glimmer yelled, throwing up her hands. "We made sure of that with the Portal and the infiltration."

“All the Portal did was take out a neutral Queen and put a Rebel on the throne. We only gained *more* problems from that stunt.” Netossa crossed her arms, coming up behind her bunkmate.

“The Portal disrupted the power dynamic within the Rebellion and caused rifts in their three strongest fighters. With those advantages, we can finally take over Animalia and cut off the Rebellion at its base.” Glimmer insisted.

“That’s the thing, Glimmer.” Spinnerella flipped through her trackerpad. “The latest accounts from the troops say that Animalia was not nearly as defenseless as our intel made us believe.”

“No matter. I’m working on our secret weapon right now. I might have already activated it if you weren’t in my way.”

“People are dying out there, Glimmer!” Netossa growled. “We have to pull back.”

“You’re not listening to me. I’m telling you that once I activate our weapon, no one else has to die. I can take on all the Princesses myself.” Glimmer said. “Now, let me through.”

“That is a pipe dream. No one can stand up to them all alone.” Netossa narrowed her eyes. “You’re being completely irrational. When is the last time you slept?”

“I wouldn’t expect you to get it, with your paltry powers.”

“Okay, listen here, young lady-”

“No, you listen to me.” Glimmer insisted. “I am not a child. I am your commander, and I’m ordering you to step aside and let me win us this war!”

“Don’t act like a child if you insist you aren’t one,” Spinnerella said quietly, moving out of the way as she spoke.

“Call the soldiers back if you want. It doesn’t matter.” Glimmer marched down the hallway, turning her back on the other

Captains. “I can do this myself.”

By the time she arrived in Moonstone Chamber, Double Trouble was waiting for her. Their eyes lingered on the bags under hers before kicking off from the wall and nodding to the Stone. However, Glimmer’s anger had cooled slightly, and the anxiety she was initially feeling was back. She stood before the Moonstone, staring it down and remembering all the pain it brought her. She was very much afraid of it, though she would never admit that.

It was powerless now, just a rock until it had a vessel to channel through. Glimmer had thought that was a good thing, that there was one less Runestone terrorizing the Etherian people. Now, she realized that she only wanted the *other* Runestones to be this helpless. This one, she could use to her advantage.

“Are you sure about this?” she asked one more time. Double Trouble sighed dramatically, like they did everything.

“Once you access the Moonstone, the power of the Heart of Etheria will channel through it into you, draining the other Runestones of their magic.” They explained again. “Or do you *not* want a magical superweapon?”

“I do, I do. It’s just….” Glimmer hesitated. “Magic has always been so complicated. Sure, I’ve trained to master and understand it, but those were spells. Just tools to direct my magic.”

“The Runestone is just like any other tool, darling. It’s all magic is.” They shrugged.

“No. this is different. This magic comes from something else, something with its own agenda.”

“You have the power,” DT assured her. “You’re just upgrading. With the Heart on our side, we’ll crush the Rebellion and you can finally have your little beau back.”

“I told you-” Glimmer cut herself off in exasperation. “Why do I pay you if you don’t listen to me?”

"I get results."

"I wouldn't mind some respect while you're at it." Glimmer grumbled.

"That can't be bought, I'm afraid." Double Trouble shrugged. "Now, let's get this show on the road." They gestured to the Moonstone, and Glimmer reached out hesitantly before putting both hands on the side of the Stone. She had seen Light Spinner do it a thousand times.

Instantly, electricity seemed to arc through her, anchoring her hands to the Stone. In her panic, she tried to pull away but was frozen in place as the power surged into her unprepared body.

The Heir….. it whispered, voice wispy and quiet amid the sounds and sparks of the Moonstone's power. *I've been waiting for you.*

Images flashed before her, most of her and Bow as children. They stood before the Moonstone many times, its power used to control and punish them. This time, she saw herself from the Stone's perspective, feeling its hate as it was forced to attack its true master.

The images slowed, and suddenly they weren't of Glimmer at all. They showed a bedroom in some Princess Kingdom. She could Light Spinner on her knees inside a glowing circle, shadows oozing off her. Bow stood outside the ring and waved his Sword in the air while his two *new friends* watched from near the door. The furry one was stone-faced, by the blonde looked like she might be sick.

Glimmer knew that Light Spinner was dying. The Stone knew, and she could feel its pleasure as its abuser slipped away through a curse brought on by her own greed. There was nothing Bow could do. A sorcerer's lifeforce is connected to their power, and Light Spinner's power had been borrowed for decades. She had long exhausted her own life and was subsiding on that which she took

from others. It was always going to end like this, eaten from the inside by the sludge that replaced her natural essence.

The Stone was gleeful, watching its user fade into nothing but shades. Glimmer didn't know how to feel. Luckily, the image flashed by fast, just as all the others did before they cut off completely. Glimmer stumbled back as her hands were suddenly released, a huge flash of light exploding from the Runestone and rippling through the entire Fright Zone. She tumbled to the floor as Double Trouble took a step back instead of coming to her aid.

"So. How about it, darling?" they asked after a moment. The surging hadn't stopped, but it wasn't painful anymore. Now it felt like she was supercharged. The exhaustion in her bones was long gone, replaced by the exact opposite feeling. She felt like she could do anything, conquer any obstacle in her way.

Loud footsteps raced up the hallway, and by the time Glimmer had gotten back to her feet, Hordak had appeared in the doorway of the Chamber.

"Force Captain! What is the meaning of this?" he growled, stalking towards her in his fancy new armor. Glimmer clenched her fists, and pink light emanated from them. Hordak looked at her hands with wide unreadable eyes. DT took the opportunity to slip out one of the Chamber's large windows. "How dare you-"

"I thought I told you, Hordak," Glimmer cut him off. Everyone was talking too slowly or rudely for her today. "Not to speak to me like an underling."

"You pompous little-"

"I'll give you one more chance to apologize." The light grew brighter and Glimmer could feel the need to release her new power, direct at her enemy just to see what it felt like when it surged from her body.

"Insubordination, then. And as Horde Prime draws ever closer. I would not have thought you so foolish."

“That’s not an apology.”

“Far from it.” Hordak growled, lifting up his arm so that Glimmer could see a cannon strapped from it.

“I see we’ve both upgraded.” Glimmer raised an eyebrow. The last time she kicked his ass, he didn’t have that. She didn’t see it being a game-changer, especially after she powered up. In fact, her power only seemed to be increasing as strange glowing runes appeared on her skin. “Maybe this time, I’ll get a better fight out of you.”

Hordak wailed and directed his arm cannon at her as Glimmer’s eyes glowed. She released the magic built up in her fists, the two beams met, and everything exploded.

“Your Majesty, it is wonderful to meet you.” Glimmer opened her eyes with a start, sitting up and frantically looking around. This wasn’t the Fright Zone. Where was she?

The last thing she remembered was defeating Hordak, Double Trouble’s brutal words, and telling Fur Face to bite her head off. But of course, the noble Rebel would never kill an unarmed opponent, or at least she didn’t get the chance before the Heart backfired and they were both consumed by pain. Glimmer had blacked out, and then she was here. Wherever here was.

“Who are you?” it was the Queen. Catra, Glimmer was pretty sure her name was. Glimmer got to her feet with difficulty. The high of the Moonstone was snuffed out, leaving her feeling even worse than before. Her head throbbed, but she curiously peaked from behind the wreckage hiding her.

She saw a tall man akin to Hordak towering over the Magicat. Catra didn’t seem as cowed as she should have been, especially without her magical mask and with a smear of blood on her forehead.

“I am Horde Prime, Lord of the Known Universe.” He placed a hand on his chest. “And you are…. C’yra the Second of Halfmoon, correct?”

“The third, and don’t call me C’yra, it’s my mother’s name.” Catra narrowed her eyes. “How did you know that?”

“Prime sees all, Your Majesty, and I have seen the little mess my Brother has made of your Kingdom. I do apologize for that.” Prime folded his hands behind his back and stepped closer to Catra, clearly invading her personal space. The Queen took a step back, but Prime followed her. “I’m afraid that his actions are not so easily repaired. I must take unseemly action.” The fake regret dripped from his voice.

“You’re here to kill us,” Catra whispered, barely loud enough for Glimmer to hear.

“I’m here to wipe this spot of the galaxy clean, just like you would any other stain.”

Catra didn’t like that. In a flash that Glimmer had trouble following, she whipped out her claws and slashed at Prime’s face, but he caught her wrist in his hand easily. Her eyes widened, and Prime allowed himself a satisfied smile before throwing her by the arm across the room.

She tumbled across the floor and skidded towards the edge of the platform, only saved from falling off the edge by her claws. A look of terror like Glimmer had never seen crossed her face as she clung to the polished, slippery ground. Prime made his way over to her before reaching down and picking her up the back of her neck. Catra flailed when he first grabbed her but quickly went limp as the pressure on her scruff increased. He held her there, over the edge, and looked her over like one might examine a faulty blaster.

“Careful, Your Majesty. That’s a very long fall, far enough for you to lose one of your precious lives. If you have any left at all.”

Catra couldn't move, but her eyes were filled with panic that Glimmer could see from across the room. "Perhaps wiping this mess away will be even easier than I thought."

"Wait." Glimmer picked that moment to emerge fully from the wreckage, standing as proud as she could in her ripped uniform and somewhat singed hair. "I don't think you want to do that." Prime turned, still dangling Catra off the cliff.

"Force Captain." He said as if remembering the name of an old friend half-lost to memory. "Pleasure to see you aboard my vessel. However, I am in the middle of business."

"If you kill Fur Face, you're giving up a lot of power." Glimmer continued.

"Do tell."

"She's part of the Heart, a big planet-sized weapon at the center of the planet. Without the Princess and their connection to the Runestones, that energy is useless." Glimmer bluffed confidently. She didn't have any clue how the Heart worked, especially since DT fed Glimmer false info for over a month.

All she needed to do was convince the man who couldn't be fooled that she was invaluable, and Catra was more of a tool than a parasite he needed to get rid of.

"Well, isn't that intriguing." Prime smiled at Glimmer. "I remember you from my Little Brother's memories, and it seems you were never so helpful to him." Hordak's memories?

"I was never loyal to him. I am loyal to the Horde and its true leader, not a defunct underling pretending to hold a candle to you."

"I see. A wise decision to forfeit your ties to him, but the flattery is a little thick." Prime's eyes turned cold. "Is there something you want that you try to butter me up so thoroughly?"

“I just want what’s best for the Horde, and that means keeping all the Princesses alive until we can use them.”

Prime seemed to ponder it for a moment, and Glimmer risked a glance at Catra. The other girl’s eyes were wide, watching Glimmer and analyzing her. No doubt trying to find out why Glimmer stepped a toe out of line for her of all people. When she figured it out, Glimmer was curious to know as well.

“Very well.” Prime said after a brief silence. He threw Catra onto the floor, where two clones immediately took her by the arms and hauled her up. “There is also a place in my light for those with use.”

From then on out, nobody paid Glimmer any mind. She only had one job on the Velvet Glove, and that was to not “bother” the Queen, which really meant to not interrupt her solitary confinement. Glimmer had been fine with that first, especially since she wasn’t particularly interested in being around one of the people who stole Bow from the Horde in the first place. But, as time went on, she got bored, and then she got lonely, and then she started feeling rebellious.

So she decided maybe bullying one of the Rebels that she hated might be fun, only to realize that the posh and prim Queen was perfectly capable of bullying her right back. That only intrigued her more.

Sometimes, Glimmer just watched the cat-woman. She didn’t do much, mostly lying around and breaking things. She destroyed every piece of her furniture in her ornate room until it was smashed up and looking like one of the Fright Zone’s cells. Occasionally, Glimmer went to her room and she wasn’t there, off having another one of Prime’s “friendly chats” that she always looked so rattled after. Glimmer didn’t know what he was doing, nor did she think she had the stomach for the details, but she had seen injection marks and wrist bruises when she got close enough to the Queen.

She felt strangely sympathetic towards Catra and more than a little envious. On the one hand, Catra had the life Glimmer wanted; a loving family, excellent Kingdom, growing and up staying with your best friend only to fall in love down the line. It was the whole package, and yet, Catra and Glimmer ended up in the same place. Catra was even worse off than Glimmer was, for as better as her life had been before the Velvet Glove. Glimmer hated that Catra had what she wanted but felt bad that this is where that path had led her.

"Are you just going to stand there?" Catra asked, curled in a ball on the floor. She was facing away from the translucent wall. Still, even with the opacity on her end, she had good enough hearing to know when Glimmer was loitering. Glimmer tapped the wall and let Catra see her.

"I was just admiring how pathetic you look." Glimmer smirked. Catra pulled up the upper half of her body and turned to glare at Glimmer, her legs still on the ground. Glimmer couldn't hold back the wince when she saw the Queen's black eye. Instantly, shame at her remark welled in her chest faster than she could push it down. "Geez, what happened Fur Face?"

"I fell." Catra muttered.

"On someone's fist?"

"I don't have the patience for your weird power trip right now. Change your attitude or leave me alone."

"If you're gonna be butt-hurt, I guess I can go easy on you today." Glimmer shrugged. "Have a topic in mind?"

"You should go. Prime could catch you talking to me." Catra settled back into her ball.

"What, I promise not to roast you anymore, okay?"

"I'm serious. Go run some simulations, or direct an army, or take a nap, I don't care. Whatever it is Prime has you doing around

here."

"In that case, I'd be leaving to do squat." Glimmer sat down, facing the cell to not crush her burgeoning wings. She had been sleeping on her stomach since they first appeared, and that was making what little sleep she got even worse quality. "My only job around here is annoying you." Catra sat up.

"He seriously doesn't have you doing anything?" she said. "You'd think someone like Prime wouldn't be so wasteful."

"Happy to hear you think I'm useful."

"No, it's just….." Catra trailed off and glanced around. "It seems like there are a lot of clones aboard, but it's all skeleton crews. Everyone left the ship to go control the Rebellion. There's no shortage of stuff Prime could be having you do."

"Really?"

"How many clones have you seen since you got here, versus how many doors were without guards and just locked?" Catra challenged. Glimmer knit her brow. Huh.

"I don't know why there are so many forces on Etheria. You Rebels aren't as troublesome as some of the other insurrections I've seen glimpses of." Glimmer shrugged.

"We handled you just fine." Catra shrugged, turning her head some. Glimmer must have been staring without realizing it.

"That was when you had He-Ra." Glimmer said offhandedly.

"What?" Catra whipped her head to stare Glimmer in the eyes.

"Bow broke his Sword. There's no He-Ra anymore." Glimmer frowned at Catra's expression. "Did you not know that?"

"What, you think Lord Passive-Aggressive would tell me things?"

"I just assumed you saw it on one of the monitors. There plenty of them."

"Well, now you know I'm not in the loop." Catra growled.

"Hey, don't get mad at me! I'm just trying to make small talk." Glimmer defended.

"I may not know what's going on in Etheria, but I do know that you only come here because you're lonely! Don't start acting like you would be here if there was anywhere else to go."

"Look, I get that you're upset that your precious Rebellion's greatest chance at winning is gone, but that is no excuse to talk it out on me."

"Isn't it? If you hadn't activated that Portal, Prime wouldn't be here, and He-Ra wouldn't be gone! If Prime blows up the planet, guess whose fault it will be?"

"None of this would have happened if you didn't trick me into activating the Heart!" Glimmer retaliated. Catra winced. "We'd still be in Despondos, and the Horde would have already conquered the planet. At least we weren't planning on killing you all!"

"Oh sure, just most of us?"

"Exactly!"

"The Horde would never have won, and they never will. Why don't you get that?" Catra's voice softened but her glare didn't. "You're on the wrong team."

"I don't think the one in the *cell* should be judging my life choices." Glimmer folded her arms.

"You think you're any better off? The second Prime gets what he needs from you, and I can't imagine what that might be, we'll be in the same boat. Or maybe he won't bother keeping you around at all."

"I'm a lot more useful than a shaved house-cat, *Your Majesty* ." Glimmer sneered. Catra snarled at the mention of her sheered mane. From what Glimmer could tell, it had some sort of significance to her or her people. Why else would Prime make an effort to get rid of it. "He couldn't afford to lock me up. I'll gain his favor with a little time."

"Maybe. But a caged bird still sings, you know."

Glimmer grumbled and got to her feet quickly, turning her back on the cell. Catra managed to identify and pick at her scabs like it was nothing. Glimmer couldn't handle the attacks when she could so easily walk away.

"You're so annoying." She hissed, walking away to get the last word.

"Years of practice." Catra yelled before Glimmer turned the corner.

She stalked through the halls, muttering to herself and letting the words replay through her head over and over. *Guess who's fault it will be* ? Glimmer could hardly stand the idea of living in a world without Bow. Without him, she would feel purposeless. Who would she fight? Who would she spend hours plotting against? Who would she-

She shook her head, dispelling the four-letter word. This wasn't the place for that, not on a ship with a man who claimed he could read minds.

Glimmer stopped in front of one of the little corner alcoves, a single ledge notched into the ship's walls for supplies or weapons. None of the shelves she had seen ever had anything on them. One more thing Catra was annoying right about. The whole ship seemed incredibly empty, even more so than it was clearly designed to be.

She climbed into the shelf and laid on her stomach. Tiredness tugged at her eyelids, but her mind still raced. It hadn't shut off since the morning she woke up without Bow. He had been her

anchor, just one more thing he took from her when he left. She replayed Catra's words over and over and thought of her own.

Your precious Rebellion's greatest chance at winning is gone. That was what she thought she wanted. No more He-Ra. So why was the thought of winning suddenly keeping her up at night?

"What are you thinking about?" Bow asked softly as they lay in their tent together. Glimmer hummed to her and looked up. The roof of the canvas was enchanted so that she could see the sky through it, even though no one could see inside. They were alone under the vast expanse, even with dozens of other tents nearby.

"Just….. how nice it is." Glimmer said after a moment.

"What specifically?"

"Well, everything is nice right now. We saved the world, and we're in love. But specifically, I'm enjoying the quiet." She admitted. The Fright Zone had been constant noise and the Velvet Glove was artificially silent to the point that it was deafening. This silence was filled with Bow's shifting next to her on the bedroll and the sounds of animals tromping through the Woods and the creatures buzzing about in the air. It was a natural silence, a peaceful one.

"It is nice." Bow agreed. Glimmer snuggled into his chest and readjusted until she could hear her favorite sound; the strong thrumming beat of her love's heart. She would never grow tired of it. "Eventually, though, we have a lot to talk about."

"I don't want to think about that. I just want to rest for a minute." Glimmer was so tired. She hadn't had a good night's rest in at least three years, maybe in her life. Everything was finally perfect, all the things that kept her up at night gone and her mind at ease. Except for one thing. "I don't want to think about what happens tomorrow when the thrill of victory wears off."

"What?" Bow lifted his head a little, and Glimmer turned her face to meet his eyes.

“You know. When the Princesses all come to their senses and remember that the War is only over from a fighting perspective. They’ll want punishments for the people left to take responsibility for all this.”

“You don’t need to worry about that.” Bow said simply, his warm expression never changing.

“I don’t want to. Not right now.”

“No. Not ever. Nothing is going to happen to you, Glimmer.”

“How can you say that?” she asked.

“You saved the life of Halfmoon’s Princess, who can easily talk down Scorpia, who can convince her mom to let you off the hook for changing sides.”

“And if that doesn’t work?”

“Well, you’re friends with Adora too, one of the Rebellion’s strongest fighters. She can go to Arachnia herself and work on terms for your pardon. Besides, she and Catra won’t make it to the end of the week before one of them proposes, so you’ll have both Halfmoon monarchs on your side before long.” Bow chuckled at his friends.

“Diplomacy might not be enough. I led the Horde, Bow. One of the biggest blows to the Alliance was an attack I planned. Mermista, Perfuma, and the others will want some revenge, likely even the ones that weren’t chipped. They were friendly enough, but that was during a war.”

None of that matters, you know.”

“And why is that?”

“Because. I won’t let anyone hurt you.” Bow promised. He folded both hands over her back and pulled her closer to him. She coiled her hands around his waist.

“You could get hurt protecting me.”

“I won’t be protecting you. You won’t need that. I’ll be caring about you, showing everyone that I love you and that we’re a package deal now. They’ll see you for your strengths in time, but for now, I’ll vouch for you.”

“You still care about me? After everything?” Glimmer stared into his onyx eyes, searching for something there.

“That’s a stupid question, Glimmer.” He smiled. “I love you, remember?”

“Yeah.” She said, closing her eyes after seeing exactly what she was searching for. In the quiet and warmth of their tent, worries assuaged, she felt the final wall between her and rest crumble. It was time to sleep and for the first time know that when she woke up, things would be better than the night before. “I couldn’t forget.”

Chapter End Notes

> This had absolutely no editing besides a run through Grammarly, so sorry about any dip in quality from the others. It was part an excuse for Glimbow cuddles, part a want to use evil Spinnetossa a little more, and part reasoning for Catra having short hair (because it is the best Catra hair). Plus, Prime being a dick is always fun. I like really evil villains.
>
> The last part of this will be up later tonight and it will a tearjerker. You were all warned. See you soon!

Here We Are

Chapter Notes

Y'all aren't ready for this.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Through the years, Glimmer loved and lost more than most. She had many more years than the average person, after all. As the centuries went by, she did her best to keep a stiff upper lip. Immorality was a blessing, but the pitfalls were deep and numerous.

One of which was the loss. As the years turned to decades and Glimmer stagnated in her thirties, the people who were once as young and spry as her seemed to age before her very eyes. Her friend group gradually shrank, even as she did her best to make new friends at every turn, until she couldn't tell whether she was at a birthday or a funeral.

Still, dates never escaped her. For a few days, she was grounded, even as time and relationships slipped like sand through her fingers. She had some traditions to keep her in the moment for those couple of days.

Five times a year, Glimmer stopped whatever she was losing herself in and did her best to be present. Twice, she returned to Etheria, ceasing her travels of the wider universe. The other three she simply observed on whatever planet she ended up on. The fifth date she could only bear to celebrate once a decade. That day, she returned to the spot she did her best to ignore the rest of the time.

Glimmer celebrated Catra's birthday was a red velvet cake and a visit to the nearest approximation of a cat café. It started out as a funny joke, but eventually, Glimmer came to enjoy simply being around the quirky creatures. Centuries passed, and cats stayed the same. It was calming.

Adora didn’t have a birthday, she usually celebrated the day after Catra’s for convenience, but Bow did. Glimmer spent time with whatever friends were around on his birthday. It was his greatest wish that she not spend the next millennia alone. While her own birthday she had nearly forgotten and most of the time only noticed after it passed, Bow’s birthday was a celebration of her life as much as his. She took stock of where she was, how far she had traveled, and how her friends were doing on that day.

Then, for whatever reason, Glimmer remembered Catra and Adora’s anniversary. This was one of her sadder personal holidays. She liked to go to a wedding happening the same day, more often than not attended by people she didn’t know, and simply exist in the cheerful setting. Yet, despite her best intentions, the fickleness of the celebration brought her down. She had already been to the wedding celebrating the universe’s most powerful love, and all marriages after seemed like a waste of time. How great could the love between these two strangers be, and how could it ever compare to the love that saved the world?

For her own wedding, she celebrated every year in one form or another, but made an effort to visit Etheria every decade. She was always happy to return to her home, in small part because it was one of the only places she could use her wings without a permit. Stupid air traffic laws.

No matter how many centuries it had been or where in the universe she was, she knew when it was time for her two-week visit. On her and Bow’s anniversary, she visited the site of the ceremony. To commemorate their love and remember its power, they had gotten through the long-neglected place where she had had her happiest moment, the memory came alive like a hologram. She could hear Catra crying as she did her best to marry her friends through the tears. She saw Adora laughing and playing keep-the-cake-away with Frosta. Best of all, she could feel Bow’s hand in hers as they danced their first dance as newlyweds.

This was the place where love was magic and memories could be reality for a short while. Their love had saved the universe, after all. The magic of Etheria was a testament to her and Bow, and this was never truer than on the spot where she had been at her lowest and highest.

A couple weeks later, she would relive less happy memories, standing over Bow's grave on the day of his passing. Glimmer wasn't sure why she tortured herself coming back here century after century, but she couldn't stay away. She was called to that spot long after the tombstone had eroded beyond reading, and the Kingdom that surrounded it, Catra and Adora's legacy, had fallen to ruin. Now, it was just a spot under a big oak tree, a small cracked stone the only mark of its importance. But Glimmer could always find it, even an eternity from now when the stone and perhaps the forest itself was gone.

"Hey, Bow." Glimmer touched down on the ground, folding her wings back into their compartment in her shirt. She knelt down in front of the stone and placed a rose on it. The shriveled rose from her last visit blew away as dust when she brushed it aside to make room. "How's eternal rest treating you? I'm sure it's nice enough."

"I've been fine, thanks. I went to see Eternia, which turns out is Adora's home planet. It was pretty cool, but they did *not* appreciate being called First One's, let me tell you." Glimmer chuckled, taking a seat on the ground. "I guess they don't like being reminded of their ancestor's colonial habits."

"I haven't done all that much since I saw you last. One of the weirdest things is that I saw this one Magicat who I could have sworn was Catra. She looked just like her; I couldn't get over it. Maybe the years are starting to get to me, but I keep seeing people I used to know. I've even seen you a couple of times." She admitted. "It's ridiculous, I know, no one could ever replace you, but every so often, someone crosses my path and I can see you in their eyes. Just a fleeting glimpse, and then they vanish back into

the crowd. Sometimes I wonder if I should chase them down and see if I was just projecting or not."

One of the petals of the rose flew away in the wind, and Glimmer watched it go wistfully. Impermanence was the curse of everything that surrounded her.

"It feels selfish to wish you were here." She whispered. "Seeing Etheria fade into an abandoned planet would have made you miserable. Most people don't even know this world's name when you mention it anymore. Saying I'm from here is a dead giveaway for my age."

"Still, I've always been the selfish one." *I wish you were here*.

"Hello?" Glimmer jumped at the sound of another voice.

"Is someone there?" a man emerged from the Woods a few dozen feet away from Glimmer. He looked around curiously, and Glimmer had to decide in a split second whether she wanted to teleport away or risk being seen by this stranger.

Etheria was an empty world, its people all having left to explore the unique and advanced worlds among the stars. Sure, she sometimes thought she saw an old woman running through the Woods with a broom, but that was just her brain being ridiculous. Glimmer was the only person who had stepped foot Etheria in nearly a millennia, so why was this man here? Was he following her? Was he dangerous?

Panic welled up in Glimmer's chest. She was completely caught off guard during an emotional moment but prepared herself to teleport as he came closer. But then they locked eyes, and she stopped.

"Oh, thank goodness, someone is here!" he exclaimed, running up to her. Glimmer's fingers twitched with the instinct to summon something and protect herself, but she pushed it down. "I thought this was a ruins planet."

“It is.” Glimmer confirmed. He frowned.

“Then-”

“I’m visiting an old friend from when this place was a thriving world.” She said simply. The man’s eyes searched and eventually landed on the small grave marker.

“Oh. I’m sorry.” He rubbed the back of his neck sheepishly.

“Is there a reason you’re here?”

“Well….. no, actually. Not really. See, I kept having this weird dream, and then one day, I woke up, got into my ship, and just started driving. I ended up here, but I also never stopped to refuel, so I’m kind of stuck.” He admitted. “I’m just glad there’s someone else around. I wouldn’t want to be alone in this place.”

“*This place*, huh? It’s not so bad.” Glimmer raised an eyebrow at his tone.

“I’ve heard weird stories about Etheria. Some people say the nature itself can talk.”

“That part is true. It doesn’t have anything interesting to say, though.” She shrugged.

“Wait, seriously?” his eyes widened, and Glimmer continued to look at them. Deep brown with a few blue flecks, warmth and intelligence shining through. These were the eyes that she loved, the ones that had closed and taken a piece of her heart with them.

So what was he doing here?

“Did you say you had weird dreams?” Glimmer asked. The guy nodded. She put her hand on the trunk of the tree nearest to Bow’s grave, and a panel opened, revealing the metallic interior of the fake plant. The man jumped.

Inside, the golden handle with the jagged blue remains of a blade sat in its display just as it had since the moment Bow no longer needed it. He left it for the next She-Ra, but no one ever rose to the title. It seemed Etheria no longer needed a champion to protect it. Until today.

“That sword. I’ve seen it.” the man said softly, approaching the open tree. Tentatively, he reached out and grabbed the handle, the gemstone glinting when he touched the metal.

“It’s yours.” Glimmer realized as he held it in his hands.

“I didn’t expect it to be…. Broken.” He poked the broken ends.

“With a little time and practice, you’ll get a better one. But it has to come from you.”

“I have to learn how to blacksmith?”

“Don’t be silly.” Glimmer chuckled. “I meant literally. If you were called it here, it means the dormant magic inside you is being drawn to Etheria. You’re being summoned as the next He-Ra.”

“I thought that was a myth.”

“Most myths have a basis of truth. It’s something you learn with age.”

“So, I’m a magical warrior?” he summarized.

“There’s a lot more to it than that.” Glimmer held out a hand. “I can show you, tell you about your past, and help you pave your future. If you’ll let me.” the man looked at her outstretched hand, and a spark of recognition passed through his gaze. Hopefully, it wasn’t Glimmer projecting.

“Ok.” He took her hand and gave her a warm smile that she had sorely missed. “Tell me everything.”

Chapter End Notes

So that it is! The thrilling and bittersweet conclusion of Golden Arrow! I may very well and put out a few one-shots set in this AU, just because that's what I do and I would be interested in exploring this some out of the confines of a ship week. That being said, this was an amazing first fandom event for me and I really appreciate the organizers, other artists, and all you amazing readers for everything you do! You're all awesome! This is the end of Glimbow Week, but I have no doubt that there will be others and plenty of other great events for me.

Thanks so much for reading, let me know what you thought in the comments, and remember. Happily ever after never ends.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!